

Remarried at 60

Choosing to Love Again at 50+

A 4-Phase Framework for the Second Marriage



SANJAY SHARMA

Author, Businessman & Coach

Book 11 of The Care Collection

Introduction: The Second "I Do"

I have not been where you are.

But I have been close. I have been the friend who got the late-night call. I have been the brother who got the long email. I have been the quiet one in the corner at the small wedding, watching two people in their sixties say "I do" for the second time — knowing the weight of that word was different than the first time.

The first time you said "I do," you were young. You were hopeful. You were full of the future. The first time you said "I do," you did not know what the marriage would cost. You did not know what the years would take. You did not know that one of you might be standing alone in the kitchen one morning, holding the other one's mug, and wondering what comes next.

The second time you say "I do," you know.

You know the cost. You have paid it. You know the years. You have lived them. You know that one of you might be standing alone in the kitchen one morning — because you have already been that person. You have already done that morning. You have already grieved that mug.

And you are saying "I do" anyway.

This book is for the person who is saying "I do" anyway. The person who has lost a spouse, or divorced after decades, or finally walked away from a marriage that had been over for years — and is now considering starting over at 50, 60, 70. The person who is looking at the second half of their life and asking the question: is there another chapter of marriage for me?

The answer is yes. But the answer is not the simple yes of the first time. The answer is the complex yes of the second time. The complex yes of someone who has been married before, who has been hurt before, who has learned before — and is willing to learn again. The complex yes of someone who knows that love is not just feeling. Love is also work. And the work is the part that matters.

This book is also for the person who is not yet sure. The person who is on the fence. The person who has been dating for a year, or two years, or five years — and still hasn't said "I do." The person who is wondering: is this really the right thing? Is this really the right person? Am I really ready to do this again?

This book will not tell you whether to remarry. This book will not tell you whether the person you are with is "the one." This book will not give you a checklist that ends with "yes, you should get married." That decision is yours. The decision is the most important decision you will make in the second half of your life. The decision deserves more than a checklist. The decision deserves a framework.

The framework in this book is built on four phases. The four phases are the way most 50+ couples move through the decision to remarry. The four phases are not a sequence you follow. The four phases are a map of the territory — so you know what you are walking into. The four phases are:

- **The Decision** — should I remarry?
- **The Courtship** — the dating, the ex-spouses, the adult children, the practical
- **The Blending** — the wedding, the family, the finances, the new life
- **The New Marriage** — the daily life, the new normal, the long game

Each phase has its own challenges. Each phase has its own questions. Each phase has its own work. The work is not the same as the first time. The work is deeper. The work is harder. The work is also more meaningful — because the second time, you are not hoping. The second time, you are choosing.

I have written this book because I have seen the second marriages that work. I have also seen the second marriages that fail. The difference is not love. The difference is not compatibility. The difference is the work. The difference is whether the couple does the work of the four phases, or skips them. The difference is whether the couple builds the foundation, or assumes the foundation is there.

I have written this book for the couple who is willing to do the work. I have written this book for the couple who is willing to build the foundation. I have written this book for the couple who is willing to say "I do" the second time — knowing what it means, knowing what it costs, knowing what it gives.

You are not alone. There are millions of people in the second half of life who are considering, navigating, or living the second marriage. The second marriage is one of the most common life stages in the modern world. The second marriage is also one of the least discussed. The second marriage is the life stage no one writes about. The second marriage is the life stage that gets a joke at the family dinner and a sigh at the therapist's office. The second marriage is the life stage that is full of hope and full of complication. The

second marriage is real.

I want to be careful with you. I want to be useful without being preachy, honest without being grim. I want to be the friend who has seen a few of these marriages through, who knows the things that matter and the things that don't, who can tell you what people wish they had done and what they wish they hadn't.

I want to be the friend who says: you are not failing.

Whatever you are doing right now — whatever you are not doing — you are not failing. The decision to remarry is one of the hardest decisions you will make. The decision deserves your time. The decision deserves your honesty. The decision deserves the work.

If you are reading this book, you are doing the work. That is enough.

Let us begin.

Part I: The Decision

Chapter 1: The Question You Are Not Asking Out Loud

There is a question. The question is in your head, in the back of your mind, in the quiet moments when no one else is around. The question is in the kitchen at 11 pm when you are doing the dishes alone. The question is in the car on the long drive when the radio is off. The question is in the bed at 3 am when the ceiling is the only thing that will look back at you.

The question is: should I remarry?

The question is not the same as "do I love this person." You may already know the answer to that. The question is also not the same as "does this person love me." You may already know the answer to that too. The question is bigger than the two of you. The question includes the children. The question includes the ex-spouses. The question includes the money. The question includes the friends. The question includes the future. The question includes the past.

The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for you. The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for the other person. The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for the people around you. The question is whether the second marriage is the right thing for the years you have left.

The question is the most important question of the second half of your life. The question deserves more than a casual answer. The question deserves more than a hopeful answer. The question deserves the work.

This chapter is about the question. This chapter is about the work. This chapter is about how to think about the question — not the answer, but the question itself. The question is the work. The answer is the next step. The next step cannot be made well unless the question is thought through well.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 5 Questions to Ask Yourself Before You Say "I Do" Again
- The 5 Things to Be Honest About (That Couples Often Hide)
- The 4 Reasons Couples Choose to Remarry (And Which One Is Yours)
- The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Decide?
- Key Terms: Remarriage, Blended Family, Pre-nup, Cohabitation
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Honest Conversation

The 5 Questions to Ask Yourself Before You Say "I Do" Again

The question of whether to remarry is a personal question. The answer is yours. But the answer is better when the question is thought through. The thinking is the work. The 5 questions in this section are the questions that 50+ couples need to answer before they can answer the big one.

- 1. "Am I ready to be married, or am I ready to not be alone?"**

The question is hard. The question is honest. The question is the difference between remarrying for the right reason and remarrying for the wrong reason.

Remarrying for the right reason is wanting the second marriage. Remarrying for the wrong reason is wanting to not be alone. The two reasons feel the same in the moment. The two reasons are not the same in the long run. Remarrying for the right reason is choosing the person. Remarrying for the wrong reason is

choosing the relationship status.

The difference shows up in the second year of the marriage. The difference shows up when the newness wears off. The difference shows up when the new person is not new anymore. The difference shows up when the loneliness that the marriage was supposed to fix comes back, in a different form, after the wedding.

If you are remarrying because you are ready to be married to this person, in the way that the first marriage was real, with the same work and the same commitment — then the reason is the right reason. If you are remarrying because you cannot stand another Saturday night alone, or another holiday without a partner, or another year without someone to hold — then the reason may be the wrong reason. The reason can be changed. The reason is the work.

- 2. "Have I grieved the first marriage, or am I still grieving it?"**

The grief of the first marriage is real. The grief is not just for the spouse who died. The grief is also for the marriage that ended in divorce. The grief is for the life you thought you would have. The grief is for the future that didn't happen. The grief is for the version of yourself that was married to the first person.

The grief needs to be done before the second marriage can start. The grief is the work. The grief is the foundation.

If the grief is not done, the second marriage will carry it. The second marriage will carry the grief of the first marriage. The second marriage will carry the unfinished conversations. The second marriage will carry the unhealed wounds. The second marriage will carry the ghost of the first marriage — and the ghost will be in the room with you, every day, for the rest of your life.

If the grief is done — if you have walked through the grief, if you have felt the grief, if you have let the grief change you — then the second marriage starts on solid ground. If the grief is not done, the second marriage starts on the grave of the first marriage. The grave is not a foundation. The grave is a hole.

- 3. "Do I know who this person is, or do I know who I want this person to be?"**

The first marriage often starts with a fantasy. The fantasy is who you think the person is. The fantasy is who you want the person to be. The fantasy is the best version of the person, the version that does not exist yet, the version you are going to create together.

The second marriage cannot afford the fantasy. The second marriage has to start with the real person. The real person has flaws. The real person has habits. The real person has the way they load the dishwasher wrong, the way they snore at night, the way they handle stress, the way they handle money, the way they handle their ex, the way they handle their children. The real person is the whole person. The real person is the person you are committing to.

If you know the real person, the second marriage can start. If you know the fantasy, the second marriage will crash. The crash is not the second marriage's fault. The crash is the fantasy's fault. The fantasy always crashes. The real person survives.

- 4. "What does this marriage cost, and am I willing to pay?"**

The second marriage has a cost. The cost is not just the wedding. The cost is the financial blending — the house, the retirement, the inheritance, the pre-nup, the will. The cost is the family blending — the adult children, the grandchildren, the holidays, the in-laws, the ex-spouses. The cost is the time — the time you have to give to the new marriage, the time you have left for yourself, the time you have left for your friends, the time you have left for the people who are no longer in your life because the second marriage takes the time.

The cost is real. The cost is not a reason not to remarry. The cost is a reason to know what you are signing up for. The cost is the work.

If you are willing to pay the cost — and the cost is not just the money, the cost is the time, the cost is the family, the cost is the parts of your old life that have to change — then the second marriage is possible. If you are not willing to pay the cost, the second marriage will fail. The failure is not a verdict on the second marriage. The failure is a verdict on the cost. The cost was too high. The marriage could not pay.

- 5. "What am I afraid of?"**

The fear of the second marriage is the most honest question. The fear is real. The fear is not a reason not to remarry. The fear is the way the second marriage shows you what you have not yet healed. The fear is the way the second marriage asks you to grow.

Common fears:

- Fear of losing the first marriage's memory. The fear is real. The memory is not lost. The memory is honored. The second marriage does not erase the first marriage. The second marriage adds to the first marriage. The first marriage is

part of the story. The second marriage is the next chapter.

- Fear of being hurt again. The fear is real. The hurt is not guaranteed. The second marriage can be the marriage where you are not hurt. The second marriage can be the marriage where the hurt is replaced by the work.

- Fear of what the children will think. The fear is real. The children are not you. The children have their own fears. The children's fears are not the couple's fears. The children's fears are part of the children. The couple's fears are the couple's work.

- Fear of getting it wrong again. The fear is real. The getting-it-wrong is the past. The getting-it-wrong is the first marriage. The second marriage is a new start. The second marriage is a new chance. The second marriage is the chance to get it right.

The fears are real. The fears are not the answer. The answer is what you do with the fears. The answer is the work.

The 5 Things to Be Honest About (That Couples Often Hide)

The honesty of the second marriage is the foundation. The honesty of the second marriage is the work. The 5 things in this section are the things that couples in the second marriage often hide — from each other, from the family, from themselves. The hiding is the enemy of the second marriage. The honesty is the friend of the second marriage.

- 1. The Money.** The money is the most common thing couples hide. The hiding is the easiest to do. The hiding is the hardest to undo. The hiding is the reason the second marriage ends in the second year.

The money hides:

- "I have more debt than I told you."
- "I have less retirement than I told you."
- "I have an inheritance I didn't tell you about."
- "I am still financially entangled with my ex."
- "I will not share my money with you."
- "I expect you to share your money with me."

The money is real. The money is part of the second marriage. The money needs to be on the table before the wedding. The money is the work.

- 2. The Ex.** The ex is the second most common thing couples hide. The ex is the past. The ex is also the present — especially if there are children. The ex needs to be talked about. The ex needs to be honest about.

The ex hides:

- "My ex and I are still in contact more than I told you."
- "My ex and I argue more than I told you."
- "My ex is not over the divorce."
- "My ex will be in the picture for the rest of my life because of the children."
- "My ex has opinions about you."

The ex is the work. The ex is the reality of the second marriage. The ex is not a reason not to remarry. The ex is a reason to be honest.

- 3. The Children.** The children are the most common source of unexpected conflict. The children are also the most important. The children are the reason the second marriage is harder than the first marriage.

The children hides:

- "My children are not on board with the remarriage."
- "My children have expectations about my money that I didn't tell you about."
- "My children have relationships with my ex that I didn't tell you about."
- "My children are not ready for me to have a new partner."

The children are the work. The children are the reality. The children need to be part of the decision, not just told about the decision.

- 4. The Health.** The health is the most important thing couples hide. The hiding is the easiest to do. The hiding is the most damaging. The hiding is the reason the second marriage ends in crisis.

The health hides:

- "I have a health condition I didn't tell you about."
- "I am on medication that I didn't tell you about."
- "I have a family history of [X] that I didn't tell you about."
- "I have concerns about my future health that I didn't tell you about."

The health is the work. The health is the foundation. The health needs to be on the table.

- 5. The Expectations.** The expectations are the most common cause of disappointment. The expectations are also the most preventable. The expectations are the work.

The expectations hides:

- "I expect you to be different from my ex."
- "I expect the second marriage to be easier than the first."
- "I expect you to take on a role that my ex used to do."
- "I expect the children to love you the way my ex's children did."

The expectations are the work. The expectations are the reality check. The expectations need to be named before the wedding.

The 4 Reasons Couples Choose to Remarry (And Which One Is Yours)

The reason for the second marriage is the most important predictor of the second marriage's success. The reason is not the only predictor. The reason is the foundation. The 4 reasons in this section are the 4 most common reasons couples in their 50s and 60s choose to remarry. The reason that is yours may be more than one. The reason that is yours may be a blend. The reason that is yours is yours to name.

- Reason 1: Companionship.** "I love this person. I want to spend my years with this person. I do not want to grow old alone. I want a partner. I want a friend. I want a person who knows me and loves me and is there at the end of the day."

Companionship is the most common reason. Companionship is also the most sustainable reason. Companionship is not just about not being alone. Companionship is about being with someone. Companionship is about the morning coffee and the evening walk. Companionship is about the inside jokes and the shared memories. Companionship is about the years.

If your reason is companionship, the second marriage is likely to work. Companionship is the foundation. Companionship is the work. Companionship is the gift.

- Reason 2: Practical.** "We are already living together. We are already sharing the house, the bills, the car, the dog, the kitchen. The marriage is just the legal paperwork for what is already real. The marriage is the next step."

The practical reason is real. The practical reason is also the most common reason the second marriage fails. The practical reason is the foundation of convenience, not the foundation of love. The foundation of convenience is the foundation that does not survive the first big fight.

If your reason is practical, the second marriage may or may not work. The practical reason is not enough. The practical reason is the supplement, not the foundation. The foundation is the love. The love is the work.

- Reason 3: Family.** "I want my grandchildren to have a grandpa. I want my children to have a step-parent. I want my family to be whole again. I want the family that was taken from me by the death/divorce. I want the family back."

The family reason is the most painful reason. The family reason is also the most dangerous reason. The family reason is the reason that does not honor the new marriage. The family reason is the reason that makes the new marriage a vehicle for the old family. The new marriage is not a vehicle. The new marriage is a marriage. The new marriage is two people. The two people are the foundation. The children are not the foundation. The grandchildren are not the foundation. The two people are the foundation.

If your reason is family, the second marriage is at risk. The family reason is not enough. The family reason is the supplement, not the foundation. The foundation is the love of the two people. The love is the work.

- Reason 4: Love.** "I love this person. I cannot imagine my life without this person. I want to be married to this person. I want to grow old with this person. I want this person in my life for the rest of my life."

Love is the rarest reason. Love is also the strongest reason. Love is the reason that survives the second year, the fifth year, the tenth year. Love is not just a feeling. Love is a choice. Love is the daily choice. Love is the work.

If your reason is love, the second marriage is most likely to work. Love is the foundation. Love is the work. Love is the gift. Love is the most important thing in the second marriage. Love is also the most fragile. Love needs to be tended. Love needs to be protected. Love needs the work.

The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Decide?

The decision to remarry is the most important decision. The decision is better when the question is thought through. The scorecard is a way to think through the question. The scorecard is not a verdict. The scorecard is a mirror. The scorecard is a way to see the readiness.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have grieved my first marriage, or my first spouse, fully | /5 |

| I know the real person, not the fantasy | /5 |

| I am willing to pay the cost of the second marriage | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about money | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about the ex | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about the children | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about health | /5 |

| I have named the expectations I have for the second marriage | /5 |

| I know why I want to remarry, and the reason is real | /5 |

| I have asked the people I trust what they think, and I have listened | /5 |

- Total:** /50

- Interpreting your score:**

- 40-50: You are ready to decide. The decision may be "yes" or "no" — but the question is thought through.

- 30-39: You are getting close. There are still some things to think through. The remaining chapters will help.

- 20-29: You are not ready. There is still work to do. The work is the question.

- Under 20: You are not ready. The decision is being driven by something other than the real readiness. The work is to slow down.

Key Terms

- **Remarriage**: A marriage after a previous marriage ended (by death or divorce)

- **Blended Family**: A family that includes children from previous relationships

- **Pre-nup (Pre-nuptial Agreement)**: A legal agreement about money and property in case of divorce

- **Cohabitation**: Living together without being married

- **Step-family**: A family where one or both partners have children from a previous relationship

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one thing you are most afraid of about the second marriage?
2. What is one thing you most hope for in the second marriage?
3. What is one thing from the first marriage that you would do differently?
4. What is one thing from the first marriage that you would keep?
5. What is one thing the children need to know before the wedding?
6. What is one thing the ex needs to know before the wedding?

Action for This Week: The Honest Conversation

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. **Have the honest conversation about money.** Both of you. With the actual numbers. The income. The debt. The retirement. The inheritance. The expectations.
2. **Have the honest conversation about the ex.** The contact. The arguments. The role. The reality.
3. **Have the honest conversation about the children.** Their feelings. Their expectations. Their relationships with the ex. Their relationships with the new partner.
4. **Have the honest conversation about health.** The conditions. The medications. The family history. The future.
5. **Have the honest conversation about expectations.** What you want. What you do not want. What you are willing to give. What you are not willing to give.

The conversations are the work. The work is the question. The question is the foundation.

A Closing Word

The question of whether to remarry is the most important question. The question deserves the work. The question deserves the honesty. The question deserves the time.

The next chapters will help you think through the question. The next chapters will help you navigate the second marriage. The next chapters will help you do the work of the four phases.

You are not failing. You are asking the question. The question is the work.

The work is the question.

Chapter 2: The First Decision — Should This Be Marriage?

The first decision of the second marriage is not "should I marry this person." The first decision is "should this be marriage at all." The question sounds simple. The question is not simple. The question is the most important question of the second half of your life.

In the first marriage, the question was a given. The first marriage was expected. The first marriage was the path. The first marriage was what everyone around you was doing. The first marriage did not need to be questioned. The first marriage just was.

In the second marriage, the question is not a given. The second marriage is a choice. The second marriage is a path you can take or not take. The second marriage is what you decide to do, with the years you have left. The second marriage is the choice. The choice is the work.

This chapter is about the choice. This chapter is about the question. This chapter is about how to think about whether the second marriage is the right thing — for you, for the other person, for the people around you, for the years you have.

Chapter at a Glance

- The 4 Lenses for the Decision (Personal, Relational, Family, Practical)
- The 3 Tests to Try Before the Wedding (Cohabitation, Travel, Stress)
- The 4 Questions to Ask the Children
- The 3 Conversations to Have with Your Ex (Yes, You Read That Right)
- The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Be Engaged?
- Key Terms: Engagement, Cohabitation Agreement, Pre-nup
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Engagement Plan

The 4 Lenses for the Decision

The decision to remarry is a multi-lens decision. The decision cannot be made from one lens. The decision needs to be made from four lenses. The four lenses are the four ways of seeing the decision. The four lenses together give you the full picture. The four lenses are: personal, relational, family, practical.

- Lens 1: Personal.** The personal lens is the most important lens. The personal lens is the lens that asks: what is best for me? The personal lens is the lens that asks: am I doing this for the right reason? The personal lens is the lens that asks: am I ready?

The personal lens is hard because it requires honesty with yourself. The personal lens is hard because the honesty may show you that you are not ready. The personal lens is hard because the readiness is not just about wanting the marriage. The readiness is about being able to do the work of the marriage. The readiness is about being the person who can be married, not just the person who wants to be married.

The personal lens also requires honesty about the past. The personal lens requires the grief of the first marriage to be done. The personal lens requires the work of the healing to be done. The personal lens requires the self to be the self that is ready for the second marriage, not the self that is still tangled with the first marriage.

The personal lens is the lens that asks the most important question: "What is right for me, in this season, with this person, in this time?"

- Lens 2: Relational.** The relational lens is the lens that asks: what is best for us? The relational lens is the lens that asks: are we the right people for each other? The relational lens is the lens that asks: can we do the work of the second marriage together?

The relational lens is the lens of compatibility. The compatibility is not just about liking the same things. The compatibility is about how the two of you handle conflict, handle money, handle stress, handle the family, handle the ex, handle the future. The compatibility is about the small daily things. The compatibility is about the way you argue. The compatibility is about the way you make up.

The relational lens is the lens that asks the second most important question: "Can we do this work, together, for the rest of our lives?"

- Lens 3: Family.** The family lens is the lens that asks: what is best for the people around us? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the children respond? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the ex respond? The

family lens is the lens that asks: how will the friends respond? The family lens is the lens that asks: how will the new family fit together?

The family lens is the lens that is most often skipped. The family lens is the lens that causes the most problems when it is skipped. The family lens is the lens that catches the things the couple did not see.

The family lens requires conversations. The conversations are with the children, the ex, the friends, the family. The conversations are the work. The conversations are not optional. The conversations are the way the family lens is applied.

The family lens is the lens that asks the third most important question: "How will this marriage affect the people we love, and are we willing to do the work of those relationships?"

- Lens 4: Practical.** The practical lens is the lens that asks: what does this marriage look like in the day-to-day? The practical lens is the lens that asks: where do we live? The practical lens is the lens that asks: how do we handle the money? The practical lens is the lens that asks: what happens if one of us gets sick? The practical lens is the lens that asks: what happens if one of us dies?

The practical lens is the lens that catches the things the couple thought they would deal with later. The practical lens is the lens that prevents the most expensive mistakes. The practical lens is the lens that turns the dreamy "I do" into the grounded "I do."

The practical lens is not the most romantic lens. The practical lens is the most important lens for the long-term success of the marriage. The practical lens is the foundation of the second marriage. The practical lens is the work.

The practical lens is the lens that asks the fourth most important question: "What does this marriage look like in 5 years, in 10 years, in 20 years, and have we planned for that?"

The 3 Tests to Try Before the Wedding

The decision to remarry is a big decision. The decision is not made in a moment. The decision is made over time. The decision is tested in real life. The 3 tests in this section are the 3 ways to test the second marriage before the wedding. The tests are not guarantees. The tests are not perfect predictors. The tests are the best way to know if the second marriage will work, before the wedding, before the commitment, before the cost.

- Test 1: Cohabitation.** Live together for at least a year before the wedding. The cohabitation is the test of daily life. The cohabitation is the test of the small things. The cohabitation is the test of how you share the bathroom, the kitchen, the bed, the money, the in-laws, the holidays. The cohabitation is the test of how you handle the disagreement about the dishwasher. The cohabitation is the test of how you handle the morning routine. The cohabitation is the test of how you handle the weekend.

If you can live together for a year and still want to get married, the second marriage is more likely to work. If you can live together for a year and the daily life is good, the second marriage has a foundation. The cohabitation is the test of the foundation.

If you cannot live together for a year — if the daily life is hard, if the small things are big fights, if the cohabitation feels like a job — the second marriage will be that, multiplied by the wedding and the commitment. The second marriage will not fix the cohabitation problems. The second marriage will amplify them.

- Test 2: Travel.** Take a long trip together. At least two weeks. In a place neither of you has been. The travel is the test of the unknown. The travel is the test of how you handle the unplanned. The travel is the test of how you handle the stress of the airport, the hotel, the foreign food, the lost luggage, the missed train.

If you can travel together for two weeks and the trip was good, the second marriage is more likely to work. If you can travel together and you handled the unknown together, the second marriage has a foundation. The travel is the test of the foundation.

If you cannot travel together without fighting, the second marriage will not fix the travel problems. The second marriage will amplify them.

- Test 3: Stress.** Go through a real stress together before the wedding. A real stress is not the stress you create. A real stress is the stress that happens — the family crisis, the health scare, the job loss, the money crisis, the ex crisis. The real stress is the test of how you handle the hard things together.

If you can go through a real stress and come out the other side still wanting to be married, the second marriage is more likely to work. If the real stress made you closer, the second marriage has a foundation. The stress is the test of the foundation.

If the real stress broke you, the second marriage will not fix the stress problems. The second marriage will amplify them.

The 3 tests are not perfect. The 3 tests are not guarantees. The 3 tests are the best way to know if the second marriage will work, before the wedding.

The 4 Questions to Ask the Children

The children are part of the decision. The children are not the decision. The children are the people who will be most affected by the second marriage. The children need to be asked, listened to, and respected. The 4 questions in this section are the questions to ask the children. The questions are not the only questions. The questions are the starting point.

- 1. "How do you feel about me remarrying?"**

The question is open. The question is honest. The question invites the children to share. The question is the way to find out if the children are on board, struggling, or somewhere in between.

The question is hard. The children may be honest. The honesty may be hard to hear. The children may say "I am not ready." The children may say "I am happy for you." The children may say "I do not know." All of these are real answers. All of these are honored answers. The answer is not the decision. The answer is the information. The information is the work.

- 2. "What are you most worried about?"**

The question is the follow-up. The question is the way to get under the surface. The children often have unspoken worries. The unspoken worries are the ones that become problems.

Common unspoken worries:

- "I will be replaced."

- "My inheritance will be taken."

- "My mom/dad will be forgotten."

- "I will have to deal with a new step-parent."

- "The new marriage will change my relationship with you."

The worries are real. The worries deserve to be named. The naming is the work.

- 3. "What would help you feel okay about this?"**

The question is the way to make the children part of the solution. The question is the way to honor the children's role. The question is the way to make the children feel heard.

The answers may surprise you. The answers may be small. The answers may be "I just want to be included in the wedding." The answers may be "I want to have a relationship with the new person at my own pace." The answers may be "I want to know that my inheritance is protected." The answers are the work.

- 4. "What questions do you have that I haven't asked?"**

The question is the way to give the children permission to bring up the hard things. The question is the way to show that you want to know, not just that you want to tell. The question is the way to model the honesty.

The children may surprise you. The children may have been holding something for years. The children may finally say the thing that has been unsaid. The saying is the work.

The 3 Conversations to Have with Your Ex (Yes, You Read That Right)

The ex is part of the second marriage. The ex is the past. The ex is also the present. The ex is the person who shares the children with you. The ex is the person who will be in your life for the rest of your life, because of the children. The ex is the person who needs to be talked to, before the second marriage.

The 3 conversations in this section are the conversations to have with the ex. The conversations are not the only conversations. The conversations are the starting point.

- Conversation 1: "I am remarrying. I wanted you to hear it from me first."**

The conversation is the courtesy. The conversation is the way to honor the ex as the parent of your children. The conversation is the way to make the ex part of the news, not the last to know.

The ex may be happy. The ex may be sad. The ex may be angry. The ex may be indifferent. All of these are real responses. All of these are honored responses. The response is not the decision. The response is the information. The information is the work.

- Conversation 2: "Here is how the children will be affected. Here is what I want to do to make this good for them."**

The conversation is the parenting conversation. The conversation is the way to make the ex your partner in the parenting, even if you are no longer partners in the marriage. The conversation is the way to show the ex that the children are the priority.

The ex may agree. The ex may disagree. The ex may have their own ideas. The ideas are the work. The work is the children.

- Conversation 3: "Here is how the money will be handled. Here is the pre-nup. Here is the will."**

The conversation is the practical conversation. The conversation is the way to make the ex know that the money is not being taken from the children. The conversation is the way to make the pre-nup part of the conversation, not a surprise.

The ex may be reassured. The ex may be suspicious. The ex may want their own lawyer. The lawyers are the work. The work is the money.

The 3 conversations with the ex are the conversations that most couples skip. The 3 conversations are the conversations that prevent the most post-wedding conflict. The 3 conversations are the work.

The Scorecard: Are You Ready to Be Engaged?

The decision to be engaged is the next step. The decision to be engaged is the step that says: yes, the second marriage is the right thing. The decision to be engaged is the step that says: yes, we have done the work of the decision. The decision is the foundation. The scorecard is a way to see the readiness.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have looked at the decision through all 4 lenses | /5 |

| I have done at least 1 of the 3 tests (cohabitation, travel, stress) | /5 |

| I have had the 4 conversations with the children | /5 |

| I have had the 3 conversations with the ex | /5 |

| I have asked the 5 questions in Chapter 1 | /5 |

| I have been honest with my partner about the 5 hidden things | /5 |

| I know the 4 reasons couples remarry, and I know mine | /5 |

| My partner and I have named the expectations | /5 |

| I have talked to at least 2 trusted friends about this | /5 |

| I have given myself at least 6 months to think about it | /5 |

- Total:** /50

- Interpreting your score:**

- 40-50: You are ready to be engaged. The engagement is the next step.

- 30-39: You are close. There are still some things to do.

- 20-29: You are not ready. There is more work.

- Under 20: You are not ready. The engagement would be premature.

Key Terms

- ****Engagement****: The formal agreement to marry, before the wedding

- ****Cohabitation Agreement****: A legal agreement for couples living together, often including money and property

- ****Pre-nup (Pre-nuptial Agreement)****: A legal agreement about money and property in case of divorce, signed before the marriage

- ****Will****: A legal document about what happens to your money and property when you die

- ****Trustee****: A person who manages money or property for someone else

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one thing you have not yet talked about that you need to talk about?
2. What is one test you have not yet done that you should do?
3. What is one conversation with the children that you have been avoiding?
4. What is one conversation with the ex that you have been avoiding?
5. What is one expectation that you have not named?
6. What is one timeline question you have not yet asked?

Action for This Week: The Engagement Plan

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. **Decide which test to do first.** Cohabitation, travel, or stress. Pick one. Plan it. Schedule it.
2. **Have the 4 conversations with the children.** Even if the children are adults. The conversations are the work.

3. Have the 3 conversations with the ex. Even if the ex is hard to talk to. The conversations are the work.

4. Schedule the engagement conversation. The two of you. The when. The how. The where.

5. Decide on the timeline. When do you want to be married? In 6 months? In a year? In 2 years? The timeline is the work.

The Engagement Plan is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the second marriage.

A Closing Word

The decision to remarry is the most important decision. The decision deserves the work. The decision deserves the honesty. The decision deserves the time.

The 4 lenses, the 3 tests, the 4 questions for the children, the 3 conversations with the ex — these are the work. The work is the foundation. The foundation is the second marriage.

You are not failing. You are deciding. The deciding is the work.

The work is the deciding.

Chapter 3: The Grief That's Still in the Room

The grief of the first marriage is the most important thing in the second marriage. The grief is the part that the couple does not see. The grief is the part that the couple does not talk about. The grief is the part that the couple thinks is done. The grief is the part that is never done.

The grief is the first spouse. The grief is the first marriage. The grief is the life that was. The grief is the future that didn't happen. The grief is the version of you that was married to the first person. The grief is the house, the routines, the inside jokes, the holiday traditions, the way the first person made you laugh. The grief is all of it. The grief is the weight of the first marriage, carried into the second.

If the grief is not grieved, the grief will be in the second marriage. The grief will be in the bedroom. The grief will be at the dinner table. The grief will be in the way you fight. The grief will be in the way you make up. The grief will be

in the way you make love. The grief will be in the way you look at the new person when the new person is not looking.

The grief is the work. The grief is the foundation. The grief is the way to honor the first marriage, by giving it the grief it deserves, before the second marriage begins.

Chapter at a Glance

- Why the First Marriage Must Be Grieved, Not Bypassed
- The 4 Kinds of Grief: Death, Divorce, Slow Loss, Unrealized Future
- The 6 Things Grief Does to the Second Marriage (If Not Worked)
- The 5 Ways to Finish the Grief Work
- The "Ghost Marriage" — Carrying the First One Into the Second
- Case Study: Ann & Tom (Ages 67/70)
- Scorecard: How Much of the Grief Is Still in the Room?
- Key Terms: Complicated Grief, Continuing Bonds, Grief Work
- Reflection Questions for the Two of You
- Action for This Week: The Grief Inventory

Why the First Marriage Must Be Grieved, Not Bypassed

The grief of the first marriage is not optional. The grief is the price of the first marriage. The grief is the cost of having loved someone for years. The grief is the cost of having built a life with someone. The grief is the cost of having lost that life, whether to death or to divorce.

The grief is not a sign of weakness. The grief is not a sign that the second marriage is wrong. The grief is a sign that the first marriage was real. The first marriage was a real marriage. The first marriage deserves real grief. The real grief is the work.

The grief cannot be bypassed. The grief cannot be skipped. The grief cannot be "moved past" by remarrying quickly. The grief cannot be "replaced" by the new marriage. The grief is not a person to be replaced. The grief is the love that was. The grief is the love that is still there. The grief is the love that needs to be honored.

If the grief is bypassed, the grief comes back. The grief comes back in the middle of the second marriage, when the new person is not looking. The grief comes back in the middle of the second marriage, when the new person does something that reminds you of the first person. The grief comes back in the middle of the second marriage, when the new person is sick, or scared, or sad, or just being human. The grief comes back because the grief was not honored. The grief comes back because the grief is owed. The grief is the work.

The 4 Kinds of Grief: Death, Divorce, Slow Loss, Unrealized Future

The grief of the first marriage is not one kind of grief. The grief is four kinds. The four kinds are the four ways the first marriage ended. The four kinds require different kinds of grief work. The four kinds are:

- Kind 1: Death.** The grief of death is the grief of the spouse who is gone. The grief is the loss of the person. The grief is the loss of the future with the person. The grief is the loss of the daily life with the person. The grief is the loss of the love that was. The grief is the deepest grief. The grief takes the longest. The grief is the most personal.

The grief of death requires:

- Mourning the loss of the person
 - Mourning the loss of the future
 - Mourning the loss of the daily
 - Honoring the love that was
 - Continuing the love that is (in a different form)
 - Allowing the new love, without abandoning the old love
- Kind 2: Divorce.** The grief of divorce is the grief of the marriage that ended. The grief is the loss of the partner. The grief is the loss of the future. The grief is the loss of the daily life. The grief is the loss of the love that was. The grief is complicated by the fact that the spouse is still alive. The grief is complicated by the fact that the marriage ended by choice. The grief is the most complex grief.

The grief of divorce requires:

- Mourning the loss of the marriage
- Mourning the loss of the partner
- Mourning the loss of the future

- Honoring the love that was (if there was love)
- Forgiving the partner (and yourself)
- Allowing the new love, without comparing to the old
- Kind 3: Slow Loss.** The grief of slow loss is the grief of the marriage that ended by inches. The marriage did not die. The marriage did not divorce. The marriage just slowly stopped being a marriage. The marriage became a roommate situation. The marriage became a business partnership. The marriage became a habit. The grief of slow loss is the grief of the marriage that died without anyone noticing. The grief is the most subtle grief. The grief is the most often unrecognized grief.

The grief of slow loss requires:

- Naming what was lost
- Mourning the marriage that was supposed to be
- Honoring the love that was (if there was love)
- Releasing the guilt of "letting it die"
- Allowing the new love, without expecting it to die the same way
- Kind 4: Unrealized Future.** The grief of unrealized future is the grief of the marriage that was supposed to happen. The marriage that did not happen. The marriage that was prevented by death, or by circumstance, or by the first marriage. The grief of unrealized future is the grief of the life that was supposed to be. The grief is the most abstract grief. The grief is the most existential grief.

The grief of unrealized future requires:

- Naming the future that was lost
- Mourning the life that was supposed to be
- Honoring the hope that was
- Releasing the future
- Allowing the new love, without resenting the old

The four kinds of grief are not mutually exclusive. The four kinds can coexist. The four kinds can be present at the same time. The four kinds are the work. The four kinds of grief require different kinds of grief work. The four kinds of grief are the work of the second marriage.

The 6 Things Grief Does to the Second Marriage (If Not Worked)

The grief, if not worked, does six things to the second marriage. The six things are the damage. The six things are the cost. The six things are the things that show up in the second marriage, sometimes years after the second marriage began.

- 1. The Comparison.** "My first spouse used to do this differently." "My first spouse never said that." "My first spouse was better at this." The comparison is the most common damage. The comparison is the way the grief shows up in the daily life. The comparison is the way the first marriage invades the second.
- 2. The Trigger.** A song. A smell. A phrase. A way of doing something. The trigger is the way the grief shows up unexpectedly. The trigger is the way the first marriage ambushes the second. The trigger is the way the new person is reminded of the first marriage, even when the new person did not mean to remind.
- 3. The Guilt.** "I shouldn't be happy." "I shouldn't be laughing." "I shouldn't be enjoying this." The guilt is the way the grief shows up as a punishment for the new happiness. The guilt is the way the first marriage punishes the second. The guilt is the way the new marriage is held hostage by the old.
- 4. The Withdrawal.** "I'm not ready to talk about it." "I need a moment." "I don't want to think about it right now." The withdrawal is the way the grief shows up as a retreat. The withdrawal is the way the new marriage is held at arm's length. The withdrawal is the way the new person is held at arm's length.
- 5. The Anger.** "You don't understand." "You can't know what it was like." "You weren't there." The anger is the way the grief shows up as a defense. The anger is the way the first marriage defends itself against the second. The anger is the way the grief fights the new marriage for the right to be remembered.
- 6. The Anniversary Effect.** The anniversary of the death. The anniversary of the divorce. The birthday of the first spouse. The wedding anniversary of the first marriage. The anniversary effect is the way the grief shows up on the calendar. The anniversary effect is the way the first marriage returns, every year, on the dates that matter.

The six things are real. The six things are the cost of the unworked grief. The six things are the work. The six things are the work of the grief work.

The 5 Ways to Finish the Grief Work

The grief work is the work. The grief work is the way to honor the first marriage, by giving it the grief it deserves, before the second marriage begins. The 5 ways in this section are the 5 ways to do the grief work. The 5 ways are not the only ways. The 5 ways are the starting point.

- Way 1: The Grief Therapy.** The grief therapy is the professional help. The grief therapy is the therapist who specializes in grief. The grief therapy is the way to do the grief work with someone who knows how to do the grief work. The grief therapy is not a sign of weakness. The grief therapy is a sign of strength.

- Way 2: The Grief Ritual.** The grief ritual is the personal ritual. The grief ritual is the candle you light on the anniversary. The grief ritual is the letter you write to the first spouse and burn. The grief ritual is the visit to the grave. The grief ritual is the way to honor the first marriage, in a way that is yours.

- Way 3: The Continuing Bonds.** The continuing bonds is the way to keep the first marriage in your life, in a healthy way. The continuing bonds is the photo on the shelf. The continuing bonds is the story you tell. The continuing bonds is the way the first marriage is part of your story, without being a wall in front of the second.

- Way 4: The Forgiveness Work.** The forgiveness work is the work of forgiving the first spouse. The forgiveness work is the work of forgiving yourself. The forgiveness work is the work of forgiving the circumstances. The forgiveness work is the work of releasing the anger and the guilt. The forgiveness work is the work of the second marriage.

- Way 5: The New Beginning.** The new beginning is the work of starting the second marriage as a new beginning. The new beginning is not the erasing of the first marriage. The new beginning is the honoring of the first marriage and the starting of the second. The new beginning is the new chapter, not the new book.

The 5 ways are the work. The 5 ways are not optional. The 5 ways are the foundation of the second marriage.

The "Ghost Marriage" — Carrying the First One Into the Second

The ghost marriage is the unworked grief in the form of a marriage. The ghost marriage is the first marriage, walking through the second marriage, unseen. The ghost marriage is the way the first marriage takes up space in the second marriage, without the couple realizing it.

The ghost marriage shows up as:

- The habits of the first marriage, in the second
- The expectations from the first marriage, in the second
- The fights from the first marriage, in the second
- The intimacy of the first marriage, in the second
- The communication of the first marriage, in the second
- The roles from the first marriage, in the second

The ghost marriage is not the second marriage's fault. The ghost marriage is the first marriage's work, unfinished. The ghost marriage is the work of the second marriage. The work is to name the ghost. The work is to honor the ghost. The work is to release the ghost, so the second marriage can be the second marriage, not the ghost of the first.

The way to deal with the ghost marriage is to name it. The way to deal with the ghost marriage is to talk about it. The way to deal with the ghost marriage is to let the new person know what the ghost is, and to ask the new person to help. The new person is not the enemy of the ghost. The new person is the partner in the work of releasing the ghost.

The ghost marriage is the work. The work is the ghost marriage. The work is the second marriage.

Case Study: Ann & Tom (Ages 67/70)

Ann was 67. Tom was 70. They had been married for 41 years. Ann was a retired nurse. Tom was a retired teacher. They had two adult daughters, both out of state.

Both Ann and Tom had been married before. Ann had been widowed after 22 years of marriage. Tom had been widowed after 28 years of marriage. Ann's first husband died of a heart attack. Tom's first wife died of cancer. Ann had been a caregiver for her first husband in the last year of his life. Tom had been a caregiver for his first wife in the last two years of her life.

When Ann and Tom met, four years after Tom's wife died and three years after Ann's husband died, they both knew the grief. They both knew the cost. They both knew the work.

The grief work Ann and Tom did:

- They each had a year of grief therapy before they started dating.

- They each had a ritual for the first spouse — Tom visits the grave monthly. Ann keeps a photo of her first husband in the living room, with a small candle.
- They had the conversation about the first marriage, in the first month of dating. They named the ghosts. They honored the ghosts. They released the ghosts.
- They agreed that the second marriage would be a new chapter, not a new book. The first marriages are part of the book. The second marriage is the next chapter.
- They each kept the rituals of the first marriage. Tom still lights a candle for his first wife on her birthday. Ann still visits the grave of her first husband on their anniversary.
- They had the conversation about the grief, when the grief comes up. The grief comes up on the anniversaries, on the birthdays, on the hard days. The grief comes up. The conversation is the work.

Ann and Tom are now 8 years into the second marriage. The second marriage is good. The second marriage is not perfect. The second marriage has the ghosts of the first marriages. The second marriage also has the love of the second marriage. The love is the work. The ghosts are the work. The work is the marriage.

Scorecard: How Much of the Grief Is Still in the Room?

The scorecard is a way to see the grief. The scorecard is a way to see what is still unworked. The scorecard is a way to see the foundation.

| Question | Score (1-5) |

|---|---|

| I have grieved the loss of my first spouse / first marriage fully | /5 |

| I have done at least one of the 5 ways to do the grief work | /5 |

| I have named the "ghost marriage" parts that I carry | /5 |

| I have talked to my new partner about the grief | /5 |

| I have rituals that honor the first marriage in a healthy way | /5 |

| I am not comparing my new partner to my first partner | /5 |

| I am not feeling guilty about being happy in the second marriage | /5 |

| I have forgiven my first partner (and myself) | /5 |

| The grief is no longer a wall between me and my new partner | /5 |

| I am free to begin the new chapter, not the new book | /5 |

- Total:** /50

- Interpreting your score:**

- 40-50: The grief is grieved. The foundation is solid. The second marriage can start.

- 30-39: There is still some unworked grief. The remaining chapters will help.

- 20-29: There is significant unworked grief. Get help. The grief work is the foundation.

- Under 20: The grief is in the way. The second marriage is not yet ready.

Key Terms

- **Complicated Grief**: Grief that does not improve over time, may require professional help

- **Continuing Bonds**: The way the widowed maintain a healthy relationship with the deceased

- **Grief Work**: The work of mourning, of feeling, of releasing, of integrating

- **Ghost Marriage**: The first marriage, present in the second marriage, unworked

- **Anticipatory Grief**: The grief that happens before the loss

Reflection Questions for the Two of You

1. What is one thing you are still grieving from the first marriage?
2. What is one ritual you keep from the first marriage?
3. What is one "ghost" from the first marriage that shows up in the second?
4. What is one thing you need to forgive in the first marriage?
5. What is one thing you need to forgive in yourself?
6. What would it take to feel free to begin the new chapter?

Action for This Week: The Grief Inventory

Within the next 7 days, do these 5 things:

1. **Write a letter to the first spouse.** The letter says everything you need to say. The letter is not sent. The letter is burned, or buried, or kept.
2. **Name the ghost marriage parts.** Make a list. The list is the work.
3. **Have the grief conversation with your new partner.** The conversation is the work.
4. **Pick one ritual that honors the first marriage.** The ritual is the work.
5. **Pick one thing to forgive.** Yourself, or the first partner, or the circumstances. The forgiveness is the work.

The Grief Inventory is the foundation. The foundation is the work. The work is the second marriage.

A Closing Word

The grief is real. The grief is the work. The grief is the foundation.

The grief of the first marriage is the most important thing in the second marriage. The grief is the weight that the second marriage carries, until the weight is grieved. The grief is the work.

You are not failing. You are grieving. The grieving is the work.

The work is the grieving.

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

S. Shharma is the author of The Care Collection - books for couples in the second half of life, written by a man who lived the silence and survived it.

He lost his wife of many years to cancer. He was her primary caregiver through every stage of her illness. He held her hand in the hospital. He sat in the waiting room at 3 a.m. He learned the silence of a marriage the way you learn a language you never wanted to speak.

He is also a businessman, an M.Sc., an MBA, and an APSCM from the Indian Institute of Management (IIM) Calcutta, with thirty years in corporate management. But these are not credentials you need to trust him. The credentials that matter are the ones in the books.

The Care Collection is not about how to fix a marriage. The Care Collection is about how to live one - even when the marriage is quiet, even when one of you is sick, even when one of you is gone.

He lives in India. He writes from the perspective of someone who has been on every side of a marriage - the partner, the caregiver, and the one left behind.

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CONNECT WITH S. SHARMA

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Published by Adorise Digital - a division of Trendy DigiStore LLC, Wyoming, USA 30N Gould St, Sheridan, Wyoming, USA

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